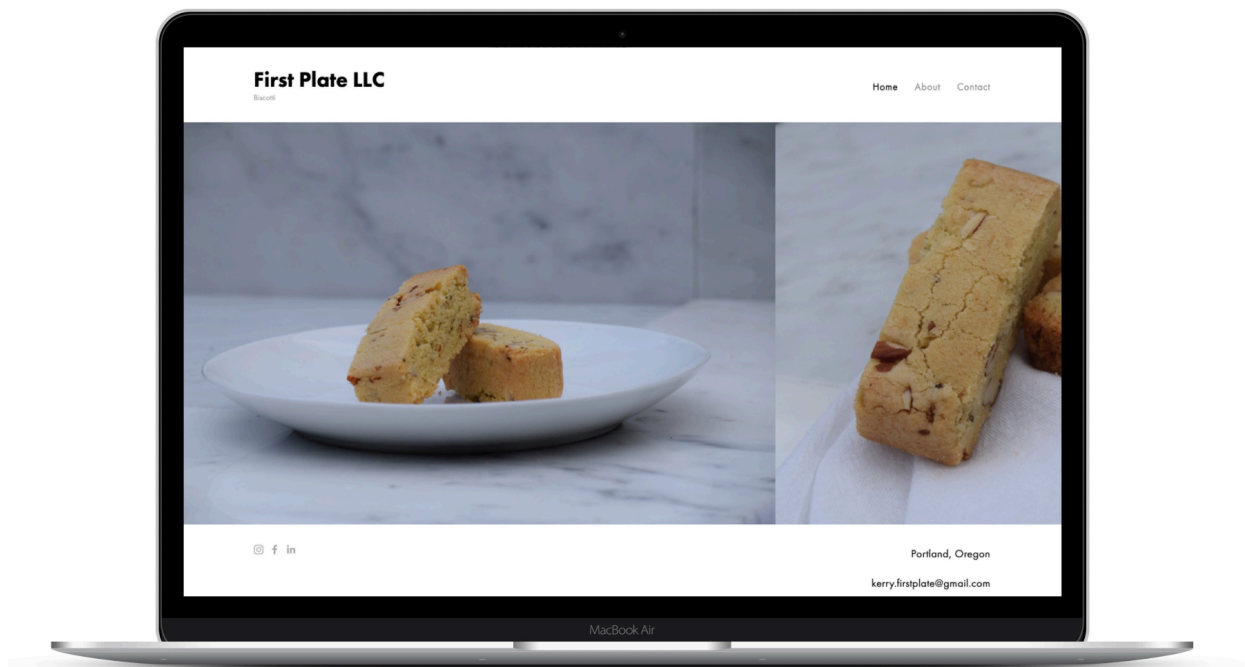




Building a Wholesale Biscotti Brand for Portland Coffeehouses

An early entrepreneurship, customer experience, and brand design project.

First Plate LLC was a small food business I founded to produce and wholesale Italian biscotti to independent coffeehouses in the Portland metro area.

What started as a creative project during high school became my first real experience identifying a customer need, validating demand, developing a product, building business relationships, and creating a brand experience from the ground up.

Project Snapshot

Project / Client: First Plate LLC, wholesale biscotti business

Timeline: May 2016 – July 2018

Role: Founder & Operator

Team / Stakeholders: Independent coffeehouse owners, coffeehouse customers, local wholesale partners

Problem Space: Identifying and filling a gap for high-quality Italian biscotti in Portland coffeehouses

Methods: Customer discovery, market validation, product testing, wholesale outreach, customer feedback, brand development

Tools: Squarespace, Instagram, Facebook, product photography, Google Workspace

Outputs: Wholesale biscotti product, local coffeehouse partnerships, website, product photography, [Facebook page](#), [Instagram account](#), ordering and fulfillment process

Outcome / Impact: Produced thousands of biscotti over two years and supplied multiple independent Portland coffeehouses while managing product development, sales, operations, branding, and customer relationships end-to-end

Focus Areas: Entrepreneurship, customer experience, food and beverage, brand design, operations, wholesale sales, product development

The Opportunity

During my freshman year of high school, an injury sidelined me from athletics and left me looking for a new creative outlet.

I originally considered starting a catering business focused on hors d'oeuvres, which is where the name **First Plate** came from. But as I spent more time in local coffeehouses, I noticed something specific: Portland had incredible coffee culture, but many shops did not offer a high-quality biscotti that felt worthy of pairing with the coffee.

Coming from an Italian household, that gap stood out to me. Good coffee and good biscotti felt like they should naturally go together, so I started exploring whether this was just something I noticed personally or a real opportunity in the local market.

The Goal

My goal was to create a high-quality, high-margin biscotti product that coffeehouses would be proud to sell and customers would genuinely enjoy.

At the same time, I wanted the business to feel personal, thoughtful, and rooted in the experience of local coffee culture - not like a generic packaged food brand.

Customer Discovery

Before investing too much time into production, I reached out to several well-known coffeehouses in Portland to understand whether there was real demand for the product.

A few shops responded, including Coffeehouse Northwest, which became an important early relationship. The owner met with me, validated the opportunity, and shared his perspective on what independent coffeehouses look for in wholesale products.

That conversation helped me better understand the buyer side of the experience:

Would a coffeehouse want to carry this product?

Would it fit naturally into their existing menu?

Would the quality meet their standards?

Would the product be easy enough to sell, store, and serve?

That early feedback gave me the confidence to move from idea to product development.

Product Development

Once I had a clearer sense of market demand, I began testing biscotti recipes.

I needed a product that met several criteria:

High quality

Authentic flavor

Strong margin potential

Reliable to produce consistently

Durable enough for wholesale distribution

Simple enough to manage as a one-person operation

After experimenting with different recipes, I landed on a classic almond biscotti that felt authentic, scalable, and well-suited for coffeehouse customers.

This phase taught me how much product experience depends on practical details: taste, texture, packaging, production time, cost, shelf life, and how the product fits into the customer's existing environment.

Market Validation

To validate the product, I brought a batch of biscotti to Coffeehouse Northwest for employees and customers to try.

The response was positive, and the shop became my first wholesale customer.

This was an early lesson in the value of getting a real product in front of real people. Instead of relying only on my own taste or assumptions, I was able to see how customers and business owners responded in the actual environment where the product would be sold.

Building the Business

Over two years, I baked thousands of classic almond biscotti and grew First Plate to serve multiple independent coffeehouses across Portland.

As the sole founder and operator, I managed every part of the business, including:

- Recipe development**
- Ingredient sourcing**
- Production and baking**
- Wholesale outreach**
- Customer relationships**
- Order fulfillment**
- Packaging**
- Delivery coordination**
- Social media**
- Website design**
- Product photography**

There were opportunities to expand into additional coffeehouses and local retail, including interest from a high-end supermarket chain. But because I was a full-time student and running the business independently from my family kitchen, I intentionally limited growth to what I could manage well.

That decision taught me an important business lesson: growth only works if the operation can support the quality of the customer experience.

Brand and Website Design

In addition to producing and selling the biscotti, I created the digital presence for First Plate.

I designed a simple website with:

A homepage featuring staged product photography
An About page explaining the story behind the business
A Contact page for wholesale inquiries

I also created a [Facebook](#) page, [Instagram](#) account to support the brand.

The goal of the website was not to create a large e-commerce experience. It was to give the business a credible, polished presence that reflected the quality and personal nature of the product.

Because First Plate was a small local brand, the visual direction needed to feel warm, simple, and handmade without feeling unprofessional.

Customer Experience

Looking back, what I cared about most was not just selling biscotti. It was creating a good experience for everyone involved.

For coffeehouse owners, that meant offering a product that was easy to order, reliable in quality, and aligned with the atmosphere of their shops.

For customers, that meant creating something that felt like a small but memorable part of their coffee ritual.

For me, it meant building real relationships with local business owners, learning how to present myself professionally, and understanding how much trust matters when someone chooses to carry your product.

Why I Closed the Business

I closed First Plate before leaving for college.

By that point, I had become deeply attached to the product, the customers, and the relationships I had built. I could not imagine handing the business off to someone else unless they had the same level of care and commitment.

While closing the business was bittersweet, it felt like the right decision. First Plate had served its purpose: it gave me my first experience building something from scratch, bringing it into the world, and learning what it takes to make an idea real.

Reflection

First Plate was one of my earliest lessons in entrepreneurship, customer experience, and self-directed problem solving.

It taught me that good ideas often start with noticing something small: a missing product, a frustrating experience, or an unmet need in a familiar environment. It also taught me that building something people value requires more than creativity. It requires initiative, consistency, relationship-building, and a willingness to learn by doing.

Looking back, this experience connects directly to how I approach UX and research today. I'm still drawn to understanding what people need, why certain experiences feel better than others, and how thoughtful details can make something feel easier, more useful, or more memorable.

First Plate also gave me an early appreciation for the business side of experience design. A product can be beautiful and well-intentioned, but it also has to work operationally for the people buying it, selling it, and using it.

What I'd Do Differently Today

If I were building First Plate now, I would approach it with a more structured research and brand strategy process.

I would want to better understand:

What coffeehouse owners prioritize when selecting wholesale food products
How customers decide whether to purchase a pastry or snack with coffee
What packaging, pricing, and placement would make the product more appealing
How the website could better support wholesale inquiries
Which brand story and visuals would make the product feel most differentiated

I would also test more product variations and gather more structured feedback from both shop owners and customers.

Even without that level of formal process, First Plate gave me a meaningful foundation in customer discovery, product-market fit, operations, and the relationship between brand, product, and experience.

Short Version for the Project Card

Building a Wholesale Biscotti Brand for Portland Coffeehouses

Founded and operated First Plate LLC, a small wholesale biscotti business serving independent coffeehouses in Portland. Led product development, customer discovery, wholesale outreach, operations, brand presence, product photography, and website design end-to-end.

Tags

Entrepreneurship · Customer Experience · Brand Design · Website Design · Product Development · Customer Discovery · Operations · Wholesale Sales · Food & Beverage · Small Business · Visual Design · Product Photography